

Work Team and Groups

Introduction

Group output and productivity are essential concerns of people managing organizations. This is expected because whatever the groups do, the organization is affected.

If the organization is to be made effective in accomplishing its goals, the groups comprising it must be managed properly. This can be achieved through the use of knowledge about the behavior of groups including work teams.

WHAT ARE GROUPS

A group may be defined as two or more persons, interacting and interdependent, who have come together to achieve certain objectives.

Groups may be classified as:

1. *Formal group*. This one is defined by the organization structure, with designated work assignments and established tasks. An example of a formal group is the economics area of a university consisting of six faculty members and an area chairman.

2. *Informal group*. This group type is neither formally structured nor organizationally determined. It is formed by individuals and developed around common interests and friendship rather than around a deliberate design. An example is a group of six faculty members of a university who love music and bring their musical instruments at a place outside the university, and play for a few hours every Saturday evening. They don't get paid for playing; they just enjoy themselves.

Types of Formal Groups

Formal groups may be further classified as:

1. *Command group*. A group composed of individuals who report directly to a certain manager. An example is a group consisting of a sales supervisor and his ten salesmen.
2. *Task group*. It is that kind of group consisting of persons working together to complete job task. An example is the group of five faculty members from different departments coordinating and preparing the semester enrollment program of the university.

Types of Informal Groups

Informal groups may be classified as follows:

1. *Interest group*. An interest group is one that is formed because of some special topic interest. In general, the group disbands when the interest declines or a goal has been achieved. An example of an interest

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group is that of employees with young children grouping together to present a unified front to management for some benefits like allowances for child care.

2. *Friendship groups.* A friendship group is one where members are brought together because they share one or more common characteristics such as age, political beliefs, or ethnic background, Friendship groups often extend their interaction and communication to activities outside of their jobs.

WHY PEOPLE FORM GROUPS

People form groups for reasons such as:

1. need satisfaction
2. proximity
3. attraction
4. goals and
5. economics

People join groups because they believe that groups are venues for satisfying their needs. Social needs, for instance, may be satisfied through interaction with group members.

Proximity is another reason why people form groups. When people work near each other, it is not hard for them to form a group.

People are attracted to each other because of similarities in perception, attitude, performance, or motivation. This condition is a positive factor in the formation of groups.

A group is formed when a number of people are required to achieve a goal. For instance, a symphony cannot be played without first forming a group of musicians.

Individual person join groups so they can obtain economic benefits not otherwise made available if they are not members of a group. A labor union, for instance, is a group of people whose primary aim is to bargain for economic benefits with the employer.

STAGES OF GROUP DEVELOPMENT

Groups are like people; they learn and they develop. How they evolve may be seen through a presentation of a standardized sequence in the development of groups. The sequence consists of different stages as follows:

1. the forming stages
2. the storming stage
3. the norming stage
4. the performing stage
5. the adjourning stage

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The Forming Stage

The first stage of group development is the forming stage. There are various ways of forming groups. One way is that person getting appointed to a discipline committee. Another is that person who is helping to form a medical mission, and another is that person who is gradually becoming part of a choral group over a period of months.

In the forming stage, the initial entry of members to a group is a primary concern. However, the specific concerns of the members consist of the following:

1. they are eager to learn what tasks they will be performing;
2. how they can benefit from group membership;
3. what constitutes acceptable behavior; and
4. what rules must be followed.

The foregoing concerns clearly indicate that this stage is characterized by uncertainty about the group's purpose, structure, and leadership. However, when members begin to think of themselves as part of a group, the forming stage is complete.

The Storming Stage

The storming stage is that stage when conflict within the group happens. Members may get involved in competition for desired assignments and disagreements over appropriate behaviors and responsibilities related to task performance.

The group experiences many changes. Expectations of the members tend to be clarified and elaborated further.

Under this stage, coalitions or cliques may form. As individuals compete to impose their preferences on the group and to achieve their desired status position, conflict may develop over leadership and authority.

When there is a relatively clear hierarchy of leadership within the group, the storming stage is completed.

The Norming Stage

This stage is also known as the initial integration stage, this is when the group really begins to come together as a coordinated unit. Cooperation and collaboration are its main characteristics. There is an open exchange of information, acceptance of differences of opinion, and active attempts to achieve goals and objectives which are mutually agreed upon.

In this stage, members feel a preliminary sense of closeness, and would want to protect the group from disintegration. When the group structure solidifies and the group has assimilated a common set of expectations of what defines correct member behavior, the norming stage is complete.

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The Performing Stage

In the performing stage, the group emerges as a mature, organized, and a well-functioning group, and it is ready to focus on accomplishing its key tasks. This stage is also referred to as the total integration stage.

Under this stage, group energy has moved from getting to know and understand each other to performing the task at hand. Intrinsic motivation and creativity are likely to emerge as the group performs.

The performing stage consists of two different sub-stages as follows:

1. The sub-stage where the group has attained a level of effectiveness that will remain more or less constant and as such, group performance will be maintained at a level sufficient to ensure survival.
2. The sub-stage where the process of learning and development of the group is ongoing so that group effectiveness and efficiency continues, and as a result, group performance will reach higher levels.

The Adjourning Stage

The adjourning stage involves the termination of activities. This stage is applicable to temporary groups such as committees, project groups, task forces, and similar entities.

The termination of the group's activities may be triggered by any of the following:

1. When the group's purpose has been fulfilled; or
2. When the group has failed to revitalize itself during the performing stage.

There are instances, however, when the activities of permanent groups are also terminated. The reasons for such termination include organizational downsizing, merging, or bankruptcy.

ROLES WITHIN GROUPS

Group efforts can be made more effective if relevant roles are played within the group. There are specific roles that are deemed important in the group process. These are the following:

1. *Knowledge contributor.* Any group would largely benefit from a member who plays this role. If he is technically proficient enough, he will be providing useful and valid information. He can be of great help in task accomplishment and the value of sharing technical expertise with other members of the group.
2. *Process observer.* The person occupying this role forces members to look at how the group functions. He is the first member affected when the group is starting to fail in doing its function. However, he is also the first to acknowledge excellent group performance.
3. *People supporter.* Some group members are not emotionally strong to face the various difficulties heaped upon them in the performance of their functions. There is a need for one member to assume the role of people supporter who provides emotional support to teammates and resolve conflicts. He listens actively to presentations made by other members. His smiles, humorous comments, and his

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relaxed appearance make others feel relaxed. Even if he disagrees with others, he supports and encourages them.

4. *Challenger.* The group needs someone who confronts and challenges bad ideas. This will prevent complacency and non-critical thinking. The challenger will succeed in his role if he possesses effective interpersonal skills. He must not appear as someone who challenges anything for the sake of challenging. His role must be regarded as a part of the problem-solving process.
5. *Listener.* There is a need for someone to listen to whatever ideas or proposals presented by any member of the group. Somebody must assume that role. Even the best proposals will go to waste if nobody cares to listen.
6. *Mediator.* It is not uncommon for group members to get involved in disputes between each other. When this happens, it will affect not only the performance of the protagonists but also that of the whole group as well. To avoid this, it is important for the group to have someone assume the role of mediator.
7. *Gatekeeper.* There is always a chance that one or two overeager members will dominate discussions. As a result, timid members may not be heard even if their views are worth listening to. There is also that chance that even good ideas that were presented and recognized may be forgotten after some time. The role of the gatekeeper is to provide the opportunity for every member to express his or her opinion. The gatekeeper will also remind every member about good ideas that were recognized previously.
8. *Take-charge leader.* - There are occasions when a group has no appointed leader, or if there is one, he could not play his role for one reason or another. The leadership vacuum cannot exist indefinitely and for the sake of group effectiveness, a team member should assume the role of the take-charge leader. With the leader, the group can then move forward by defining its mission and determining its objectives.

ADVANTAGES AND DISADVANTAGES OF GROUPS

Working in a group offers the following advantages:

1. More inputs from various perspectives can be made available for effective decision making
2. Synergism is more likely when people work together as a group
3. People in the groups are more supportive of decisions that were formulated with their assistance
4. It allows the efficient exchange of information for effective problem solving;
5. The opportunity for fulfilling the safety, affiliation, and esteem needs of group members is made available; and
6. Group members get mutual support from each other

Working in a group, however, has disadvantages which include the following:

1. Group activity is usually slower and more cumbersome because every member has the opportunity to make contributions;

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2. Group meetings are held to disseminate strictly routine data that could be more efficiently conveyed in writing through interoffice memorandum. When this happens, the effectiveness of the group is undermined;
3. The group's decision may be diluted by every member's input making the decision ineffective;
4. Accountability is often a problem with group activity;
5. There are occasions when some members shirk responsibility and let other members of the group do the work;
6. When the group is highly cohesive and motivated, outside criticism tends to be ignored as group members look inward for reinforcement of each other's opinions.

Groupthink

The previously-cited item No. 6, which is a disadvantage of working in a group, is actually referred to as "groupthink". This term may be briefly defined as a deterioration of mental efficiency, reality testing, and moral judgment in the interest of group cohesiveness. Individual thinking is brought in line with the average quality of the group's thinking.

An illustration of groupthink may be provided as follows: Ten years ago, Mr. George Publico was assigned to train five bright new employees. He was satisfied with their performance and he facilitated their promotion to supervisory positions. Later, Mr. Publico was directed to form a group that will perform special tasks like finding effective ways of cost-cutting. The five new supervisors were assigned to him as members of the group. They were thankful that they were given the opportunity to work with their benefactor.

During group meetings, the five members always defer to their leader. Whatever problems are tossed to the group, they determine Mr. Publico's view, and not wanting to displease him, they indicate their approval. Their job as group members became routine and easy because it is their leader who does all the thinking.

How to Minimize Groupthink

The existence of groupthink is an indication that the group may be functioning effectively. There are some ways of minimizing groupthink. These are:

1. Monitoring group size, so it will not grow large enough to intimidate some members to perform well;
2. Encouraging group leaders to play an impartial role by actively seeking input from all members and avoid expressing their own opinions, especially in the early stages of deliberation;
3. Appointing a member to play the role of devil's advocate; and
4. Using exercises that stimulate active discussion of diverse alternatives without threatening the group and intensifying identity protection.

TECHNIQUES IN GROUP DECISION MAKING

There are various techniques used in group decision making. Four of these are presented as follows: 1. 2.

1. interacting groups
2. brainstorming
3. nominal group technique

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4. electronic meeting

Interacting Groups

Interacting groups are typical groups in which members interact with each other face-to-face. The essence of interaction is the sending and receiving of information through oral, written, and nonverbal communication.

The main drawback of this technique is its susceptibility to "groupthink".

Brainstorming

Brainstorming is a group problem-solving technique which promotes creativity by encouraging members to come up with any ideas, no matter how strange, without fear of criticism.

In brainstorming, the participants are required to observe the following procedures:

1. generate as many ideas as possible;
2. be creative, freewheeling, and imaginative;
3. build upon, extend, or combine earlier ideas; and
4. withhold criticism of others' ideas.

When group members meet to determine the best solution to a problem, some members tend to be hesitant in suggesting solutions for fear of being ridiculed. An underlying principle in brainstorming is to minimize or eliminate the element of hesitation by deferring judgment on ideas forwarded.

The chance of making a good choice depends on the number of ideas listed. To improve the chance of selecting a good solution, adherence to the principle of "quantity breeds quality" is a feature of the brainstorming technique.

Nominal Group Technique

The nominal group technique is a group decision-making method in which individual members meet face-to-face to pool their judgments in a systematic but independent fashion. The group decision is the mathematically pooled outcome of individual votes.

The following discrete steps are undertaken in the nominal group technique:

1. Individual members quietly list their ideas.
2. Ideas are written on a chart one at a time until all ideas are listed.
3. Brief time is allotted so that questions can be asked, but only for clarification.
4. A written vote is taken and the group decision is announced.

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Electronic Meeting

Electronic meeting is a decision-making technique wherein members interact through computers, allowing anonymity of comments and aggregation of votes. This technique features the distinct advantages of anonymity, honesty, and speed.

Any group member can anonymously type any message he wants and it flashes on the screen for the entire group to see at the push of a member's keyboard. Since anonymity is assured, members can honestly express their views. Because of computers, messages are quickly relayed in an electronic meeting.

WHAT ARE WORK TEAMS

Work teams are important elements of organizations. They are the groups expected to deliver high performance when the organization requires it.

A work team is a formal group comprised of people interacting very closely together with a shared commitment to accomplish agreed-upon objectives. Differences between Workgroups and Teams Groups and teams are not similar. A workgroup is one that interacts primarily to share information and to make decisions to help each member perform within his or her area of responsibility.

Groups emphasize individual leadership, individual accountability, and individual work products.

Teams emphasize shared leadership, mutual accountability, and collective work products.

TYPES OF TEAMS

There are various types of teams. The most common are:

1. problem-solving teams
2. self-managed work teams
3. cross functional teams
4. virtual teams

Problem-solving Teams

Problem-solving teams are groups of 5 to 12 employees from the same department who meet for a few hours each week to discuss ways of improving quality, efficiency, and work environment.

Members of problem-solving teams share ideas or offer suggestions on how processes and methods can be improved.

Self-Managed Work Teams

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A self-managed work team is one that is empowered to make decisions about work schedules, task allocations, job skills training, performance evaluation, selection of new team members, and controlling quality of work. Team members are collectively held accountable for the team's overall performance results.

Each member is expected to be able to perform many different jobs. Because of this, team members are provided with training in performing more than one job on the team.

The traditional duties performed by managers or first line supervisors such as planning and work scheduling, performance evaluation, and quality control are taken over by the team members.

The advantages of self-managed work teams are:

1. improved flexibility of staff;
2. the reduced number of job classifications result to more efficient operations;
3. absenteeism and turnover rates are lower, and
4. organizational commitment and job satisfaction are at higher levels.

The disadvantages of self-managed work teams are:

1. Implementing the concept takes time (as long as several years);
2. the cost of training the team members is high;
3. there are inefficiencies created during the training period; and
4. some employees are not able to adapt to a team structure.

Cross Functional Teams

A cross functional team is one composed of employees from about the same hierarchical levels, but from different work areas, who come together to accomplish a task. An example is a team of supervisors coming from the design, manufacturing, and purchasing units of the company, plus a representative from a major supplier

The advantage of a cross functional team is that it allows people from different units to perform the following:

1. exchange information
2. develop new ideas
3. solve problems
4. coordinate complex projects

The main disadvantage is that it consumes much time as the members learn to work with diversity and complexity. On the psychological aspect, building trust and teamwork also take time, especially when the people involved are from different backgrounds.

Virtual Teams

Virtual teams are those that use computer technology to tie together physically dispersed members in order to achieve a common goal. Members do the same things as members of face-to-face teams. They also share information, make decisions, and complete tasks. The difference is they do it with the aid of computers."

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Virtual teams can meet without concern for space, time, or physical presence. They can work even if they are thousands of miles apart.

A major disadvantage of virtual teams is the high cost of the required supporting technology and training.

DEVELOPING EFFECTIVE TEAMS

Teams can be made effective if the following are observed:

1. Team size must be kept as small as possible. The larger the team, the more difficult it would be to manage it.
2. The team members must have a sufficient range of skills, information, and/or experience to do the task.
3. Team members must have a sense of common purpose like the feeling that what they are doing is critical to the success of the organization.
4. The team must be free to develop its work procedures.
5. The team must have a sense of accountability.

TURNING INDIVIDUALS INTO TEAM PLAYERS

Team players are indispensable human assets of many organizations, and these organizations would want to make sure that they are available when their services are needed. Team players, however, do not just come out of the blue. Organizations must provide the right environment so they can become possible. An important concern, however, is to turn individuals into team players. The available options consist of the following:

1. selection
2. training
3. rewards

Selection

In searching for team players, it must be remembered that not all people are alike. Some were born natural team players, while others could become team players if they are properly trained. There is a third category of persons who cannot become team players, even with training. They should not be considered for selection.

Training

Training is a way of turning individuals into team players. communication, negotiation, conflict management, and coaching. They should be made to attend training courses in problem solving.

Fully trained members of the team must be well-versed in the company's philosophy regarding teams, the team mission, and new roles and responsibilities individuals will have as a consequence of being part of the team.

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Rewards

Rewards are powerful motivators. This is also true if it is directed towards effective teamwork. With adequate rewards, team members would be motivated to be effective team players. For instance, a collaborative team member may be rewarded with a promotion, a pay raise, or any other form of recognition.

Behaviors that should be rewarded include training new members, sharing information with teammates, helping to resolve team conflicts, and learning new skills that the team needs.

POTENTIAL TEAM PROBLEMS

Even teams encounter problems which can affect their effectiveness. Two notable team problems involve the following:

1. changing membership
2. social loafing

Changing Membership

Newly formed teams need time to turn into mature groups. However, this could be disrupted by frequent changes in its composition. Members may drop out temporarily or permanently for reasons like:

1. transferring to a higher priority project;
2. the occurrence of a personal problem requiring extended leaves of absence; or
3. accepting a job in another company.

The higher the membership turnover is, the bigger is the team's problem. To address such concern, the team must learn to manage its internal turnover through the following:

1. recognition of the potential problems brought by high turnover;
2. development of a plan for managing turnover; and
3. thinking through how best to integrate new members

Social Loafing

Social loafing refers to the tendency for individuals to expend less effort when working collectively than when working individually. The reasons for social loafing are:

1. the members think their contribution is less noticeable; and
2. the members prefer to see others carry the workload.

To minimize or eliminate social loafing, some means of identifying individual efforts must be provided. If this is not possible, it may be proper to consider first whether the team approach is appropriate for the task at hand. It may be wise to consider an analysis of the following:

1. the nature of the task;
2. the qualifications and desires of the participants; and
3. the time and cost constraints.

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Summary

Work teams and groups are important concerns of organizations. A group consists of two or more persons, interacting and interdependent, who have come together to achieve certain objectives.

Groups may be classified as either formal or informal. The types of formal groups are: command group, and task group. Informal groups consist of interest groups and friendship groups. People form groups due to need satisfaction, proximity, attraction, goals, and economics.

Groups develop in a standardized sequence consisting of the forming stage, storming stage, norming stage, performing stage, and adjourning stage. Roles are played within groups consisting of: knowledge contributor, process observer, people supporter, challenger, listener, mediator, gatekeeper, and take-charge leader. Groups bring advantages and disadvantages to the organization.

Groupthink is a disadvantage of organizations, it refers to the deterioration of mental efficiency, reality testing, and moral judgment in the interest of group cohesiveness. However, there are ways of minimizing groupthink.

The techniques used in group decision-making are: interacting groups, brainstorming, nominal group technique, and electronic meeting. A work team is a formal group comprised of people interacting very closely together with a shared commitment to accomplish agreed-upon objectives.

Teams may be classified as problem-solving teams, self-managed work teams, cross functional teams, or virtual teams. Individuals may be developed into team players by means of effective selection, training, and rewards. The potential problems of teams consist of changing membership and social loafing.

Assessment

Answer the following questions in a separate sheet of paper. Submit to your teacher via google classroom email or messenger.

File name should be [Surname/Activity 8/Leadership in Organization]
ex. **Dela Cruz Activity 8 Leadership in Organization**

1. Why must organizations be concerned with groups?
2. What is a group? How may they be classified?
3. What is an interest group?
4. Why do people form groups?
5. What are the stages of group development?
6. What triggers the termination of group activities?
7. What role does the gatekeeper play in a group?
8. What are the disadvantages of working in a group?
9. How may one minimize groupthink?
10. What is a work team?

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